Introduction

‘May You Live in Interesting Times’

11 October 2008, Washington DC

It was a cold, rainy, gloomy October evening when finance ministers and central bank governors from the G20 countries had assembled in HQ2 Conference Hall of the international Monetary Fund (IMF) office complex in downtown Washington DC. For sure, the ministers and governors had not travelled to Washington for this special meeting of the G20; they were already scheduled to be there for the annual meetings of the IMF and the World Bank over the weekend.

The G20 meeting was a last-minute add-on, convened at short notice, to discuss ‘the probable negative impacts of the present acute global financial situation on world growth’. Given the uncertainty and turmoil of the preceding few weeks following the collapse of Lehman Brothers in mid-September, the anxiety of the finance policymakers to get together to exchange notes on what had happened and what would likely happen was understandable.

Brazil was the chair of the G20 in 2008. I received the meeting notice on 9 October, shortly before catching the overseas flight out of Mumbai. On the morning of the meeting, 11 October, when I was already in Washington, I got another mail from the G20 chair asking if I could be one of the two lead speakers in the second session of the meeting which would focus on the implications of the current turmoil for emerging markets. The Brazilian finance minister and the current chair of G20, Guido Mantega, much in the news in subsequent years for his strong position on the international currency wars, was the other lead speaker.